

● HARD

● CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Text Structure and Purpose

9 questions · ~14 min

04

Q1

CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Some studies have suggested that posture can influence cognition, but we should not overstate this phenomenon. A case in point: In a 2014 study, Megan O'Brien and Alaa Ahmed had subjects stand or sit while making risky simulated economic decisions. Standing is more physically unstable and cognitively demanding than sitting; accordingly, O'Brien and Ahmed hypothesized that standing subjects would display more risk aversion during the decision-making tasks than sitting subjects did, since they would want to avoid further feelings of discomfort and complicated risk evaluations. But O'Brien and Ahmed actually found no difference in the groups' performance.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. It argues that research findings about the effects of posture on cognition are often misunderstood, as in the case of O'Brien and Ahmed's study.
- B. It presents the study by O'Brien and Ahmed to critique the methods and results reported in previous studies of the effects of posture on cognition.
- C. It explains a significant problem in the emerging understanding of posture's effects on cognition and how O'Brien and Ahmed tried to solve that problem.
- D. It discusses the study by O'Brien and Ahmed to illustrate why caution is needed when making claims about the effects of posture on cognition.

“How lifelike are they?” Many computer animators prioritize this question as they strive to create ever more realistic environments and lighting. Generally, while characters in computer-animated films appear highly exaggerated, environments and lighting are carefully engineered to mimic reality. But some animators, such as Pixar’s Sanjay Patel, are focused on a different question. Rather than asking first whether the environments and lighting they’re creating are convincingly lifelike, Patel and others are asking whether these elements reflect their films’ unique stories.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined question in the text as a whole?

- A. It reflects a primary goal that many computer animators have for certain components of the animations they produce.
- B. It represents a concern of computer animators who are more interested in creating unique backgrounds and lighting effects than realistic ones.
- C. It conveys the uncertainty among many computer animators about how to create realistic animations using current technology.
- D. It illustrates a reaction that audiences typically have to the appearance of characters created by computer animators.

In 2023 literary scholar Jeremy Douglass cautioned technology investors and enthusiasts who predict conventional books' ultimate displacement by newer forms of media. Douglass observed that the concept of an “interactive” text is much older than technologists assume, extending back to the first time readers scratched notes into a text’s margins. In addition, newer media, such as video games, haven’t replaced older forms of entertainment, such as comic books, but rather exist alongside them. Douglass believes that rather than supplanting books, technology is simply making new forms of expression possible.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It challenges the stance of the investors and enthusiasts who are mentioned earlier in the text.
- B. It explains the basis for the claim made by the technologists mentioned in the text.
- C. It suggests that academics are better suited than investors to see the potential uses of contemporary interactive texts.
- D. It provides a historical anecdote about the technological challenges involved in reading the earliest interactive texts.

The following text is adapted from Herman Melville's 1855 novel *Israel Potter*. Israel is a young man wandering through New England during the late eighteenth century.

He hired himself out for three months; at the end of that time to receive for his wages two hundred acres of land lying in New Hampshire. [...] His employer proving false to the contract in the matter of the land, and there being no law in the country to force him to fulfil it, Israel—who, however brave-hearted, and even much of a dare-devil upon a pinch, seems nevertheless to have evinced, throughout many parts of his career, a singular patience and mildness—was obliged to look round for other means of livelihood than clearing out a farm for himself in the wilderness.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It implies that Israel treasures a particular characteristic of his personality when that characteristic should usually be regarded as a flaw.
- B. It suggests that if not for a certain aspect of his character, Israel might not have been as easily thwarted in his ambition to establish a farm.
- C. It shows why Israel would not have been able to undertake the enormous amount of labor necessary to run a farm even if he had owned the necessary property.
- D. It explains why, when the situation requires it, Israel is able to undertake courageous acts that others would generally avoid.

Studying late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century artifacts from an agricultural and domestic site in Texas, archaeologist Ayana O. Flewellen found that Black women employed as farm workers utilized hook-and-eye closures to fasten their clothes at the waist, giving themselves a silhouette similar to the one that was popular in contemporary fashion and typically achieved through more restrictive garments such as corsets. Flewellen argues that this sartorial practice shows that these women balanced hegemonic ideals of femininity with the requirements of their physically demanding occupation.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To describe an unexpected discovery that altered a researcher's view of how rapidly fashions among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas changed during the period
- B. To discuss research that investigated the ways in which Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas used fashion practices to resist traditional gender ideals
- C. To evaluate a scholarly work that offers explanations for the impact of urban fashion ideals on Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas
- D. To summarize the findings of a study that explored factors influencing a fashion practice among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas

In 2020, rap artist and professor A.D. Carson published the first peer-reviewed rap album about his experiences with Black masculinity called “i used to love to dream.” Typically in peer review, experts evaluate scholarly articles prior to publication. For Carson’s album, dubbed a “mixtap/e/ssay,” peer review involved both scholars and rap artists. In combining elements of a mixtape album with scholarly essays that connect Carson’s lyrics to historical and contemporary contexts for listeners both inside and outside academia, Carson’s album helped redefine how scholarship is created and shared.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To compare the relative public impact of scholarly articles and albums
- B. To capture one scholar’s opinion of a new rap album
- C. To explain why a certain rap album is particularly innovative
- D. To describe how each step of the peer review process unfolds

Several studies have found negligible electoral consequences for governments that impose fiscal austerity measures, yet some European governments recently suffered electorally due to their austerity programs. Evelyne Huebscher and colleagues attribute this incongruity to governments' tendency—not followed in the recent European cases—to implement austerity programs strategically to avoid electoral costs (e.g., setting spending cuts to take effect only after the next election), which has obscured the inherent political risks of austerity measures in the election data scholars have examined.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It explains a discrepancy between what has been observed in study settings and what has been observed in real-world settings that the text goes on to assert is attributable to the studies not using real-world data.
- B. It identifies a conflict between research findings and recent events that the text goes on to suggest is a consequence of a complicating factor in the data used to generate those findings.
- C. It presents a long-standing divergence in research findings that the text goes on to say is due to different groups of researchers using data that derive from different electoral circumstances.
- D. It describes a recent exception to a general pattern in research findings that the text goes on to explain is a result of researchers underestimating the significance of inconsistencies in the data they've analyzed.

Astronomers are confident that the star Betelgeuse will eventually consume all the helium in its core and explode in a supernova. They are much less confident, however, about when this will happen, since that depends on internal characteristics of Betelgeuse that are largely unknown. Astrophysicist Sarafina El-Badry Nance and colleagues recently investigated whether acoustic waves in the star could be used to determine internal stellar states but concluded that this method could not sufficiently reveal Betelgeuse's internal characteristics to allow its evolutionary state to be firmly fixed.

Which choice best describes the function of the second sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A. It describes a serious limitation of the method used by Nance and colleagues.
- B. It presents the central finding reported by Nance and colleagues.
- C. It identifies the problem that Nance and colleagues attempted to solve but did not.
- D. It explains how the work of Nance and colleagues was received by others in the field.

Changes to vegetation cover and other human activities influence carbon and nitrogen levels in soil, though how deep these effects extend is unclear. Hypothesizing that differences in land use lead to differences in carbon and nitrogen levels that are not restricted to the topsoil layer (0–30 cm deep), Chukwuebuka Okolo and colleagues sampled soils across multiple land-use types (e.g., grazing land, cropland, forest) within each of several Ethiopian locations. They found, though, that across land-use types, carbon and nitrogen decreased to comparably low levels beyond depths of 30 cm.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It describes a phenomenon that scientists do not fully understand, explains a research team’s hypothesis about that phenomenon, and then describes a finding that led the team to refine the hypothesis.
- B. It introduces an unresolved scientific question, presents a research team’s hypothesis pertaining to that question, and then describes an observation made by the team that conflicts with that hypothesis.
- C. It discusses a process that scientists are somewhat unclear about, introduces competing hypotheses about that process, and then explains how a research team concluded that one of those hypotheses is likely correct.
- D. It explains a hypothesis that has been the subject of scientific debate, discusses how a research team tested that hypothesis, and then presents data the team collected that validate the hypothesis.